



**SAHITH
THEEGALA**

AGE

25

TURNED PRO

2020

TOUR STARTS

74

(57 cuts made)

TOUR WINS

1

CAREER EARNINGS

\$10.49

million



AKSHAY BHATIA

AGE

21

TURNED PRO

2019

TOUR STARTS

38 (17 CUTS
MADE)

| 89

TOUR WINS

1

CAREER EARNINGS

\$2.17 million

credited his success to his parents who had migrated from India in the 1980s and made sure he had access to good facilities as a child. He hopes his and Bhatia's success will motivate others in India to also pursue their dreams. "I'm very proud of my Indian heritage," says Theegala. "I love seeing Indians rise to the occasion in sports... Neeraj Chopra winning the first gold medal in track and field for javelin for India; that's huge for the country."

Theegala says that by winning on these forums, they're hopefully breaking some stereotypes about athleticism and competing in sports at the global stage. "It means a lot to me... and hopefully, this is the start of something really good for Indian sports."

Separately, Bhatia's journey has been rather unconventional and bold in terms of its trajectory. A rising star, Bhatia turned pro in 2019 and became the youngest American to play in the Walker Cup, which pairs top

US amateurs against British and Irish players. Before that, he had won the 2017 US Junior President's Cup and the PGA Junior Tour.

Facing ultra-competitive conditions where success is almost the only guarantee for survival comes as second nature for those growing up in a milieu like the US and Europe. This tough winnowing process swiftly separates those with a real desire for success from those who aren't focussed and determined.

Clearly, with its relatively sparse infrastructure and a completely different set of economic dynamics in operation, India has a long way to go before it can regularly produce such high achievers. However, as Theegala says, India has produced a Neeraj Chopra, and where there is one, there will inevitably be more. **BT**

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